

In Writing

The principle. Sandra does hair in her front room in Chatham, and she does not do writing. When she got a parking ticket she knew was wrong and the council told her it had to be in writing, she asked Code Overlord for something that would write to them and post it, and its agents built her No Envelopes. It worked, so everybody in Medway wanted theirs doing, and No Envelopes answered the council so politely, so often and so correctly that the council went bust. Then Parliament wanted to talk to her about it, and she would only deal in writing, so in the end the House of Commons had to come to her front room and queue on her stairs like everybody else.

Why it is funny. The council told her it had to be in writing, and she takes them at their word, all the way up to Parliament. Every rung is one more reasonable thing she asks Code Overlord for, and every one works perfectly. The more important the people who want her, the less she is prepared to move a single appointment.

Sandra, outside her house in Chatham, holding a ticket: 17 APRIL 2028. Permit not clearly displayed. Seventy pounds.

"It was on the dashboard." A pause. "I rang them. Forty minutes. They said it has to be in writing."

"And?"

"I don't do writing." A pause. "So I had Code Overlord make me something that writes to them and posts it."

Her son had put Code Overlord on the laptop in the hall. She said one sentence into her phone, "write to them and post it I'm not doing envelopes", and windows opened on the laptop all night, building it. By the morning it worked: photograph a ticket, and a proper letter goes to the council.

"Nine days. Cancelled." A pause. "No Envelopes, I called it."

Sandra does hair in her front room. One chair; the customers wait on the stairs. Whatever they ask for, they get Sandra's haircut: short, with one curl stuck down on the forehead.

Everybody on the stairs had a ticket from parking outside.

"So I had Code Overlord do them a form. They pay a pound for the stamp."

At six every night it posts the lot, on its own. By the summer it was doing every ticket in Medway, and Medway Council started writing back to say no.

"So I had Code Overlord make it answer them and all. Same night."

Medway's head of parking:

"We answer every letter. In writing. We always have."

So every no got an answer, every answer got a letter back, and in the end every ticket was cancelled.

In October Medway Council went bust. The interviewer reads the notice.

"Envelopes: two million, one hundred and four thousand pounds." A pause. "Was that you?"

"I was right in April."

Then the House of Commons wanted to know how a hairdresser in Chatham had bankrupted a council.

"They rang. They wanted me up London on the Wednesday."

"And?"

"I told them. It has to be in writing."

So they wrote, and No Envelopes answered the same night, NOENVELOPES.COM along the bottom: she doesn't do London; she can see you Thursday, in the front room. They wrote again. It wrote back again: Thursday, in the front room. Within a month the House of Commons had spent more on envelopes than Medway. So they came to her.

"Six hundred and fifty of them." A pause. "So I had Code Overlord make it give them all a number."

On the Thursday they queue up her path, past the chippy, each holding a number from No Envelopes. The Speaker was number four hundred and twelve. He asked to go first.

"Did you let him?"

"There's people in front of him."

They wait on the stairs, and ask their questions from the chair.

"What did they ask you?"

"How I done it."

"What did you tell them?"

"There's a form."

"Did you do their hair?"

"They was in the chair."

It took till Christmas. They came down the path one at a time, every one with Sandra's haircut.

"Did they ask for that?"

"They asked for a tidy-up."

In the hall, to camera:

"I still don't do writing. No Envelopes does the lot. My son put Code Overlord on for us. Best thing he ever done."

In January the Commons sits. Both sides have the same haircut, one curl each. A Member gets up out of turn. The Speaker, with his curl:

"Order. Order." A pause. "There's people in front of you."

Card. Nothing after it.

What a Code Overlord user sees, and nobody else does. One plain sentence thumbled from a phone into a session on the laptop in the hall, and windows opening underneath it in an empty room. A schedule at six every evening, the instruction she gave it still showing, running with nobody in. A second ask, in its own session, that makes her app answer whatever comes back, and a third that numbers six hundred and fifty visitors. The form, the pound, the letters, the replies to the council, every answer to the House of Commons and the Members' numbers are all No Envelopes, which her agents built and which does all the work.

Accent. The whole cast is Medway: Chatham, Gillingham, Strood, north Kent Estuary, the interviewer, the head of parking, the Speaker and all six hundred and fifty Members included. Cast and voice it that way without exception and never spell it: the Medway is in the grammar, "I don't do writing", "up London", "make it answer them and all", "How I done it", "They was in the chair", "Best thing he ever done". The date is on the first ticket, 17 APRIL 2028, and nowhere else.

Three things to decide. The tag: the Speaker, with his curl, telling the House "There's people in front of you", which puts her rule and her haircut in the Commons in one frame. Recommendation: keep it, over ending on her praise. The crushed Corsa: the old ending, where she will not jump her own queue and her car is crushed and ticketed, is out, because it was a second story after the peak. Recommendation: leave it out. Kent twice: Ask Our Bev is also the Medway towns and also climbs to Westminster. Recommendation: move Ask Our Bev to another region, because In Writing's bankrupt council has to be a real one and this is it.

How this was made. Condensed to two minutes from the long version beside it, 2026-09-19-film-in-writing-long.md, which was rebuilt from his note on one road with every cause said out loud.